

tions,” she adds.

Sungjemlila Longkumer, a certified cosmetologist, believes that influence has now shifted decisively towards creators and communities because creators do not fear showing flawed but real skin. “People are tired of the ‘perfect’ airbrushed skin on billboards. They want to see how a foundation actually sits on textured Indian skin in 35°C heat. My community trusts me because I’m a real person, not a star living in a bubble,” she says.

The influencer economy has played a decisive role here. Unlike celebrities, creators offer context, education, and relatability. They break down labels, compare price points, talk openly about acne, pigmentation and hair loss, and normalise trial-and-error. Beauty consumption has moved from aspiration to information.

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AFFORDABLE LUXURY

Another defining trend is the rise of affordable luxury brands that deliver premium formulations and packaging without luxury pricing. Young Indians are willing to spend, but they want value, transparency and performance.

This has opened space for digital-first brands that bypass traditional advertising, invest in community-building, and rely heavily on creator-led discovery. Beauty, today, is less about impulse buying and more about curated routines.

“Brands like Minimalist or The Ordinary blew up because they gave us the raw ingredients without the fluff. Also, the homegrown brands that actually understand Indian problems like hyperpigmentation or pollution-proofing are winning. We love brands that feel pharmacy-meets-luxury clinical results with a beautiful, shelf-worthy

MARKET MOMENTUM

\$34 BILLION

India's beauty
and personal care
market by 2028
from \$21 billion
currently

3,500

Number of beauty
and grooming
products in the
online space

96%

Brands operating
primarily in the
e-commerce space

SOURCE
NYKAA-REDSEER REPORT

aesthetic,” says Longkumer.

The Indian beauty and personal care market is poised to reach \$34 billion by 2028, up from \$21 billion now, driven by a surge in online penetration and a growing preference for high-quality, premium beauty products, according to a report by Nykaa and consulting firm Redseer released last year. As e-commerce democratises the beauty business, beauty and grooming products

are fast filling up the online space with more than 3,500 brands, as per the report.

Beauty and lifestyle content creator Rida Tharana says, “The industry is now open to a much wider range of people... different skin tones, skin types, hair textures and everyone brings their own version of what has worked for them.” The audiences also note that these products are already used and reviewed. According to her, that makes people feel closer to them and more confident about trying them, as it feels more believable and real compared to traditional ads.

TIER II INDIA LEADS

Perhaps the most underestimated force in India's beauty boom is Tier II and Tier III cities. Higher disposable incomes, deeper smartphone penetration, regional-language content and social commerce have unlocked massive demand. For brands, growth is no longer metro-first.

Fashion and beauty e-commerce platform Myntra has reported that its beauty business is now growing at nearly twice the pace of the broader online category, clocking over 50% year-on-year growth in the last two months alone. As per the company's media statements, beauty now contributes one in every five orders on Myntra, fuelled by explosive adoption among Gen Z and Tier II/Tier III customers.

Myntra CEO Nandita Sinha has been vocal about how Gen Z, which now forms 60% of their beauty user base, is highly experimental and spends nearly twice as much as other cohorts.

Myntra has reported that Tier II and Tier III cities are outpacing metros, with growth rates that are almost 50% higher; new segments like K-beauty, J-beauty,